Malice In Underland

A Novel of Silvora Reefs

The Adventures of Oliver Onions

> *NATURE OF FAULT: structural, longstanding, load-bearing. REMEDY: none available. Recommend company.* — Maintenance form, Hang-hai Quiet Apartments, Unit 2F

Part One — The Harbour

1 · The Bruise

The sky over Silvora Reefs, chief town of Buutwayn Parish and of the whole sunless country called Underland, bruised the way it always did, slowly, from violet toward a crimson it never quite committed to, and Oliver Onions lay on his back in eighteen inches of harbour water and watched it with the mild interest of a man who has not yet been told that he is the one who ought to be worried.

Something had come down out of that sky. He was fairly sure of it. The evidence was that he was wet, that the harbour smelled of hot metal apologising for itself, and that somewhere above the fog there were rotor blades: slow ones, heavy and unhurried, the sound of a machine that had arrived and meant to hold its position.

He did not know his name.

He did not know the town's, either, though the word *Silvora* sat at the front of his head like a parcel with no paperwork. He knew he was tall, and forty-odd, and that one knee had opinions. He knew the cold had stopped being an event and become a condition. And he knew, with a certainty that went down underneath everything else he had lost, that a little way off to his left, in the shallows, an elephant was waiting for him to finish a sentence.

The elephant was purple. He was the exact purple of a bruise on its third day, and he wore an ornate saddle that had never once been sat in, and he stood the way very old things stand, as though the standing were a favour he was doing the ground. His name was Furthermore. Nobody had told Oliver this. He knew it the way he knew his own hands.

"Well?" said Oliver. His voice came out rusted. "Go on, then."

Furthermore drew himself up. The fog leaned in. Something enormous was being assembled behind those soft grey eyes, something that had been in preparation since before there were words to prepare it in—

“Nevermind,” said the elephant, without moving his mouth; the word arrived from somewhere behind Oliver’s eyes, unhurried, and let all the air out at once.

Oliver laughed. It was a short, astonished bark, the first sound in the whole business that had belonged to him, because he had been maddened by that word for as long as he’d had a mind to be maddened with, and he would have known it in the dark. He did not know who he was. He knew precisely who this was. It seemed, on balance, a place to begin.

2 · The Correction

He waded out and turned and looked at what he had come down in.

It lay half in the shallows and half up the shingle where it had stopped. It was large, and it was broken, and it was broken in a way that objects of that size are not supposed to break: not crumpled, not burnt, but *struck*, as though something had hit it again and again in the same place until the place gave way. The metal was hot where the water wasn’t touching it. It ticked as it let the heat go, unevenly, like a clock being wound by someone who kept stopping to think.

There was no cockpit. There were no controls, no seat, no restraints, no housing for an instrument, nowhere a hand could have gone. There was no room inside it in which a man could have been sitting.

He had been inside it. He was as sure of that as he was of the elephant.

On one intact panel, stencilled small and neat and a little off-square, was a serial number, and beneath the serial number were four words in a language that turned into English while he was reading it and refused to stay that way afterwards. He knew that he had understood them. He could not have said what they were.

His tailcoat was a deep purple and his waistcoat an olive green, and the tide had gone through the pockets of both and left them heavy with gold, which seemed to him a poor way to treat a man who had lost his hat. The hat was the one thing the water had taken. At the top of the shingle was a flat stone, and on the flat stone, laid out in a row as neatly as cutlery, were four things it had left alone.

A monocle, gold, on a gold chain, in a case worn shiny at the hinge by a great many openings.

A pocket watch, gold, stopped at 3:33, with its second hand held mid-sweep instead of resting against the pin. A spring runs down and the hand comes to rest. This one had been *held*.

A cane with a gold onion for a handle: a joke somebody had made once, long ago, and then had to go on living inside. The wear on the shaft said they had lived inside it cheerfully.

And a notebook, waterlogged, ninety pages of it gone to a single blue smear.

Three pages were still legible, dry in the middle of the ruin. The handwriting matched the callus on his second finger, same pressure, same slight backward lean, and he had no memory of writing a word of it. Under the thumbnail of that same hand was a stain he took for ink, violet going to crimson, and it did not come off when he rubbed it on his coat.

He put the monocle to his eye.

Through the gold, the wreck was not a wreck. It was a *correction*. Something had struck out, heavily, repeatedly, with enough force to tear the surface it was striking, and the tearing was what had come down over the harbour, and the sound of it was rotors because that was the nearest sound a man had for it. There had never been a machine. He had come through a hole made by somebody pressing too hard on a thing they were trying to remove.

He lowered the monocle. The wreck went back to being a wreck, which was not an improvement.

“Furthermore,” said Oliver, to the harbour in general, “if we’re to believe the evidence of our senses—which, admittedly, seems rather presumptuous—then something here is deliciously askew.”

It was the first thing he had said that sounded like him, and he found that a great deal of him was still there to say it.

The notebook was worse. Through the gold the blue was not a smear at all. It was ink being *withdrawn*, page by page, back toward a nib, in a slow and careful retraction that had been going on for some time and was nearly finished. The three dry pages were not survivors. They were what had not been taken back yet.

The first held a map of a town he didn’t remember, drawn in his own hand: a harbour, a street of lamps, a building marked with an X, and under it, in the backward-leaning script, *THEN WHAT?* The second was a letter that began *Dear Furthermore,* and stopped. The third was a list.

Eleven names. Nine of them had been ruled through, not scribbled out but *ruled*, once, neatly, the way a man crosses out something he is sorry about. *Olivier d'Oignon. Ollie Onyon. Oswin Unyan.* The nine went on in that vein, an alphabet of near-misses. The last two lines were blank. The ink there had gone first, and the lines hung on the paper, empty, like places laid at a table.

He read it twice. Then, because nothing in his life had prepared him to do otherwise, he put the notebook, the watch, the monocle and the cane into his coat, and went to look for the road.

The tide had left prints in the sand, and they were his; he knew the length of that stride. They ran from the water's edge to the foot of the slipway, straight and even, without the shortening and hesitation of a man on a wet slope in the dark. Walking like a man crossing a room whose shape he knew.

He lifted the monocle again. It showed him the same prints, and then showed him the part the eye had skipped: they did not come out of the sea. They *began*. Four feet out, under three feet of water, they began, already walking. And alongside them, coming down from the wall to meet them, was a second set, in a worn-heeled boot, which turned at the water's edge and hurried back up the hill beside his own.

Someone had been waiting for him. Someone had been in a hurry about it.

3 · The Slipway

The prints led him up the slipway to the harbour wall, and at the top of the slipway there was a truck.

It was a pickup the colour of weak tea, idling with its lamps dipped, and a man was leaning on the bonnet with his hat pushed back, wiping his hands on a towel in the manner of someone who has been wiping them for hours and has forgotten what they were wiped for. He was broad and slow and perhaps sixty. The shirt said DAREK. He had the look of a man who had been standing there since before there was anything to wait for.

"Sorry about your wait," the man said.

Then he stopped, and frowned at the harbour, and seemed to listen to his own sentence arriving.

"Ah. You ain't waited yet. Gimme a second. I'm runnin' a touch ahead this mornin'."

Oliver stood on the slipway with harbour running out of his boots and found, to his surprise, that he was prepared to trust this man entirely. It was not a decision. It was more like finding a stair where one expected a stair.

“You know me,” he said.

“I know the Ols that comes in the shop. Tuesdays. Large vanilla, dipped, no sprinkles, and he reads the menu like he ain’t read it for eleven years.” Darek took in the wet coat, the cane, the monocle swinging on its chain. “Don’t know who you are, though. You’re standin’ different.”

“I don’t know who I am either.”

“Well,” said Darek. “That’s a start. Get in the truck.”

Afterwards Oliver would remember nothing of the drive. There would be a place in his memory where it ought to have been, smooth as a closed wound, and when he pressed on it he would feel only that something had happened there and had been handled with great tenderness. What he would remember was the truck stopping at the foot of a steep street, and the heater ticking, and Darek looking at the windscreen rather than at him.

“This is as far as I’m let go,” said Darek.

“Let by whom?”

Darek looked at the windscreen for some time. “Well, now,” he said. “Mind how you go, Ols.” And the second *Ols* was said the way you say a name to a man on a platform, either for the first time or the last.

Oliver got out. The truck did not leave until he had gone a good way up the street, and when he looked back its lamps were still there, dipped and patient, the way you watch a child cross a road.

Green lampposts went up the hill in a line. Each threw considerably more shadow than its flame could account for, and the shadows could not agree with one another about where the light was coming from. At his left shoulder something large and soft and purple kept pace, and the street, which had views on everything else, did not mention it.

He walked up between the lamps, into the parish.

Part Two — The Parish

4 · Hang-hai Quiet Apartments

The sign said HANG-HAI QUIET APARTMENT, with a gap at the end of it sized for a letter that was not there. Years ago someone with a spray can, a steady hand and a considerable sense of humour had supplied the missing S, and it was a snake: a snake coiled into the shape of the letter, painted so well that it seemed to be in the middle of deciding something.

Oliver had looked at that snake every day for eleven years. He knew it the instant he looked, the way he knew the knee. It had been in a different coil every single time, and he had never once caught it moving.

He lifted the monocle. The snake was not paint and was not a snake. It was a letter that had been typed wrong, struck through, and typed again, and the strike-through was what he had been reading as a body all these years. It was still wet. It had been wet since before he moved in.

He lowered the monocle and went in, because he was cold, and because there are things a man can only afford to learn one at a time.

The building had nine floors, and the second of them hung from something overhead rather than standing on anything below. The corridor ran from the stair to his door in a length that had never twice been the same. Tonight it was thirty-odd feet, and he walked every one of them with the feeling of being accompanied in the wrong direction. On the board outside his door were Landy's repair notices.

WINDOW 2F — WEATHER NONCONFORMING — RESOLVED.

DOOR 2C — OPENS TO 3A ON THURSDAYS — RESOLVED.

Each form carried the same four-lobed seal, stamped in violet: FILED WITH THE COALITION FOR CULPABILITY AND CONSTRUCTIVE CHANGE. NO FURTHER ACTION IS REQUIRED OF THE RESIDENT. NO FURTHER ACTION IS AVAILABLE TO THE RESIDENT. It took him a moment to see that the lobes were letters: four capital Cs, back to back, in a ring.

There were twenty-two forms. Through the gold, the word RESOLVED stopped being a word. It was the same three letters typed over and over on top of themselves, until the ribbon gave out and the paper gave up and agreed to be black in that shape. Nothing had been resolved. Something had been *insisted on*, at length, by someone who could not fix the corridor and could not stop filling in the box.

Inside, the flat had arranged itself into the shape it used when he had been away: chair angled toward the window, desk under its usual weight of paper, the smell of wet wool coming off a tailcoat he had not yet taken off. The lamp was on. He did not recall leaving it on, but the lamp and he had an arrangement, and it had never yet been put in writing.

The desk was a door on two trestles. The left trestle was split along the grain and had never been mended; it had been shimmed, with something folded. He got down on his bad knee and drew the shim out.

It was a page: one of Landy's forms, filled in beautifully, in a hand considerably better than Landy's. Under NATURE OF FAULT it said *structural, longstanding, load-bearing.* Under REMEDY it said *none available. Recommend company.*

He did not raise the monocle. He knew what it would tell him: that the desk was not holding the shim up, that the shim was being held *in*, that somebody had kept one piece of paper somewhere safe and dry for eleven years and used a broken trestle as the excuse. He put it back exactly as it had lain, the way you would cover someone sleeping.

The window over the harbour stood a hand's breadth open and let in the rotors. Four days they had been going, he understood, at a constant bearing and a constant volume, and nobody had mentioned them; he knew that the way he knew the snake. He opened the window the rest of the way. With nothing between him and the sound, it stopped being rotors. It was a page being turned. Over and over, at the pace of someone checking what he already knew he had read, from a room that was not in the direction the sound was coming from.

By the window was a clean rectangle on the floor, with four small round depressions at its corners, pressed into the grain over so long a period that the wood had stopped intending to come back up. Something heavy had stood here for years. It had not been dragged away; a dragged thing leaves a lip of dust at the trailing edge, and there was none on any of four sides. It had been lifted straight up, by two men's worth of effort and no men, and the dust inside the rectangle was younger than the dust outside it. It had been taken and returned many times. The last time was inside the fortnight, and it had not come back.

Through the gold the rectangle was not empty. There was a machine standing in it, and the machine was being used, and the man using it had his back to Oliver and did not turn round.

The building was full of noises: a radio on four, a bath running on six, someone moving furniture on two. In eleven years he had never met or named one of those tenants. He tried now to put a face to the radio and found there was nothing to put it on. The radio was

playing to an empty room. The bath was running into a bath nobody was going to get into. It did this on a schedule, and the schedule had been written by somebody who had once lived in a full building and remembered what one sounded like.

In the hallway hung a tall spotted glass. He had passed it ten thousand times. Now he stood in front of it and held still, a tall, lanky man with drying auburn hair and deep blue eyes in a ruined purple tailcoat, regarding himself with a sardonic tilt of the eyebrow that he recognised, with some relief, as his own, and on a long enough hold the corridor behind his reflection stopped being the corridor. It became a room with a low ceiling and one lamp with a green shade, and a desk under the lamp, and a great deal of paper on the desk, and a chair pushed back from it. When he raised the monocle, the gold declined to reflect the corridor at all and gave him the room directly: a desk, a lamp, a typewriter with a page in it.

There was a paragraph on the page. He could read it from where he stood; the page leaned toward him, the way a person leans who wants to be read. It was a paragraph about a man standing in a hallway looking into a mirror.

He stood very still, it said, *and read it.*

Oliver stepped back from the glass.

The last line, he was almost certain, added itself: *and stepped back from the glass.*

5 · The Management

He went down the stair because he could think of nothing else to do.

Asimov Sobeleaux kept the manager's office on the ground floor, behind a door that said KNOCK and, beneath it, in smaller letters, *or don't, I shall hear either.* He was a large, kind man in his sixties, with a silver-streaked beard and weathered hands, who had once been a fisherman and once a cartographer and had not entirely finished with either. The walls were pinned with charts of waterways that appeared on no map, and he was bent over one of them with a pair of dividers when Oliver came in.

"Ah. Ze tenant who survives sings. Come in, come in. Mind ze corridor, it is longer today zan it vas contracted to be, да?"

Oliver asked him why.

Asimov explained. It was a beautiful explanation. It had a beginning, a middle and an end; it dealt with load, and distance, and the way a building must be said to *stretch* to accommodate its occupants; it was delivered with dividers; and it made perfect sense for

exactly as long as Asimov was talking. Oliver nodded all the way through it. He could feel it going even as he nodded, like a coin in a pocket with a hole. By the time he reached the door he had only the last line, which Asimov had pressed on him like a gift.

“One man needs more corridor zan four men do,” said Asimov. “One man has furzer to go.”

On the stair, Luigi Luigi was mopping in the manner of a man conducting. He was short and wide and moustached, and he went through the building every day with a bucket and a squeegee and a total conviction that what he was cleaning was *dirt*. This was a gift, of a sort. Rooms Luigi had just done behaved themselves. Stairs agreed to be stairs. The residents called him the Patron Saint of the Squeegee, and he permitted it as a thing that happened to other people.

“Mama mia! Mister Onions!” He did not interrupt the arc of the mop. “The dirt, she is everywhere! But Luigi, he make it clean again, is like a blessing from above! You walk on the wet floor, you take the consequences up with a higher authority. Me, I only do the floor.”

“Do you ever—” Oliver began, and could not think how to finish. *Notice that the stair is nine steps going down and eleven coming up? That the window on the landing has a different harbour in it every Tuesday?*

“The floor,” said Luigi kindly, “is the floor.” And he squeegeed the sentence away.

Lying Landy was under the sink on the first-floor landing, which was where he lived, in the sense that nobody had ever found him anywhere else. He was the building’s handyman, and he was immaculately dressed, with a pressed waistcoat and a bow tie and a pocket square, for a man whose elbows were in a drain. He emerged at Oliver’s step like a conjuror out of a hat, spanner in one hand and a smile that had been put on before it was needed.

“Mr Onions! Two-F! Now, the window. I’ve been at the window. It’s sorted. It’s completely sorted and I’d not want you to worry about the weather in it.”

“I haven’t asked about the window.”

“No. No, you haven’t. And that’s very, that’s very *good* of you.” The smile held, though something behind it was working hard at the holding. “Every repair I make, Mr Onions, I make *properly*. That’s the trouble. Do you know, I’ve been mending that corridor eleven years and it’s never once been the same corridor twice? I fix the one thing and the thing next to it takes offence.” He laughed, a very small laugh. “Resolved, though. All resolved. Two-C opens onto the kitchen now, which I grant you it didn’t used to, but that’s not a fault, that’s a feature. I’ve the forms.”

“I’ve seen the forms.”

“Then you know,” said Landy, with real relief, “that nothing more can be done,” and slid back under the sink.

Oliver stood on the landing for a while with the feeling of having been told the truth by three people in a row and having been given none of it.

6 · Sorry About Your Wait

Durry Kwain stood at the bottom of the hill where the street met the harbour road, a low square building with a plastic cone on the roof that had been dipped, over the years, in so many layers of sun and fog that it no longer committed to a colour. The window was lit. It was always lit. Behind the counter Darek Dwayne Wayne was wiping a surface that was already clean.

“Well hey there, y’all!” said Darek Dwayne Wayne, and it was a moment before Oliver understood that the *y’all* was plural, and that the second party was at his left shoulder.

“Large vanilla, dipped, no sprinkles,” he said, while the bell over the door was still deciding whether to ring.

It was across the counter before Oliver reached a stool. Oliver sat, and took it, and discovered that he was starving. Then Darek set a second cone on the counter a little further along, to Oliver’s left, plain, and turned away to wipe something else that was clean. When Oliver looked again the second cone was gone, and the air beside him let out a long, contented breath, and neither man said a word about it.

Down the counter, a very short man in a Durry Kwain visor was standing on an upturned crate to work the soft-serve machine. Nobody had said anything, but he rounded on Oliver all the same. “What’s that SUPPOSED to mean?! Just because I’m SHORT doesn’t mean I can’t reach the ice cream! I’m not FALLING SHORT of anything here!” His badge said *Timmy Tyler.* Something small and dark crossed in front of Oliver’s ear with a thin *bzzz* and a murmur, “Sí, amigo, I hear many interesting things…”, and was gone before he could turn his head, and Darek, without looking, gave the air a very gentle swat of reproof.

“Nothin’ come down over that harbour,” said Darek, a full beat before Oliver had opened his mouth to ask. “Not last week, not last year, not never in my life. You came *up*.”

“Up.”

“Up out of the water, in a stride. I come down to the slip at four in the mornin’ on account of a feelin’, and I’m sat there with the engine off, and the water goes flat, and you walk out of it like a door you’d been holdin’ shut. Never seen a man so set on gettin’ somewhere he didn’t know the way to.”

“What did I say? In the truck.”

Darek began to wipe the counter again, and stopped.

“Wasn’t the alphabet,” he said. “It was your own name, said over and over, all the way up the hill, backwards. *Snoino Revilo. Snoino Revilo.* Like it was somebody you was tryin’ to warn me about.”

Oliver turned it over. *Oliver Onions.* Letter for letter, both ways, the way a word is when it was made by someone who could not decide which end to begin at.

“And the rotors?” he said. He had not meant to. It came out of him the way water comes out of a tipped boot.

Darek’s face did something complicated and kind. He leaned on the counter on both forearms.

“Everybody hears it,” he said, low. “Every soul on this hill hears it, all day, every day. And we don’t say it, Ols, ’cause the first fella who says it out loud is gonna make it *true*. Right now it’s a noise. You say *there’s a helicopter over the harbour* in this town, in a voice, where folks can hear you, and then there’s a helicopter over the harbour. And it’s got to have come from someplace. And it’s got to be *for* somebody.” He looked at the dark window. “So we let it be a noise. That’s the whole town’s plan.”

It was not much of a plan. But Oliver, who had a page being turned in his head and had been trying to say so since the window, understood that he had been about to say it, and that Darek had caught him at the lip of it the way a man catches a cup. He closed his mouth. He took what he knew, the page and the room and the man with his back turned, and he did not say it. He carried it instead. He took the weight off the counter and put it somewhere inside himself where it would keep.

Darek noticed, a beat late, which was not how Darek noticed anything.

“You just did somethin’, Ols,” he said slowly. “I don’t know what it was. I’d like the record to show I noticed it.”

Eventually Oliver asked about the corridor, because it seemed a smaller thing to ask. Darek told him about March, when Oliver had left his keys on the counter and Darek had walked them up.

“Eleven foot, that hall. I counted, ’cause I’m a counter. You told me after it was thirty-odd, and you looked at me like I’d lied.”

“It’s thirty-odd when I walk it.”

“Alone,” said Darek.

“Alone.”

“Well.” Darek straightened. He had the face of a man who had thought about this for a long time in a shop that sold ice cream and had arrived at nothing but the answer. “Whatever it is you’re workin’ at, you got a standin’ invitation to be in here doin’ it. Sit at the window. Talk at me. Just don’t do the whole thing alone, huh. On account of, apparently, that’s how the hallway gets long.”

Oliver ate the cone to the end, slowly, which seemed to be what was wanted. The second cone had left no drip. Furthermore sighed again, and the counter, which had never been asked to bear that weight, bore it.

7 · The Möbius Strip Club

The Möbius Strip Club had no front that anyone could agree on. It was a narrow brick building on Mercy Street with a neon sign, and the sign said MÖBIUS STRIP CLUB in pink, and the pink buzzed in a rhythm that seemed to Oliver to be spelling something. He held the monocle up to it. Through the gold the letters rearranged themselves, without any fuss, into REVILO’S TRAP BUILT.

He lowered the monocle and looked at the door for a time. Then he went in, because it was the only door in the street with a light on, and because he had a growing suspicion that whoever had arranged the evening was not offended by being noticed.

A woman stood in the doorway of the inner room as though she had been standing there since the building was laid. She had red hair pinned up like a threat and a dinner jacket cut for someone who might need to move in it, and she regarded Oliver with the cool, total attention of a person who has been waiting for something that was described to her in detail.

“You’re standing in my doorway,” said Ginny Ginja, “with your weight on your back foot and your eyes doing the room. Left, up, left again, exits. That’s a guard. That’s a man expecting to be hit by architecture.”

“I’m told it’s a reasonable thing to expect.”

“By whom?”

“Everyone,” said Oliver, “in a kind voice.”

Ginny very nearly smiled. “Welcome to the club. Stay on the marked paths, respect the dancers, and remember: what happens in a Möbius strip eventually comes back around. Come in. Mind the corridor.”

The corridor did not turn. That was the trouble with it. It ran from the front room toward the back with every sign of a straight line, and Oliver walked it, and it carried him round in a way he could not afterwards describe and brought him out facing the front room again, with the same coat on and the cane in the same hand, as though he had been turned over like a page and the page had gone on being the same one. The club was a long room of booths and low lamps, and at the bar three alligators in dinner jackets were sitting very straight. *INSTA-GATORS*, said a card on the bar, because this was a town that put a card on everything.

On a small stage at the far end, a dancer in the colours of fallen leaves stopped mid-turn to look at a calendar that had not been on the wall a moment before. “It’s getting close to… you know,” said Vember, to nobody. “I can feel the leaves changing. Maybe I should just… disappear for a while.” Nobody on the floor so much as blinked. The place was run with the discipline of a barracks and the courtesy of a sickroom, and the dancers were guarded like something fragile and valuable, which they were.

“The back wall,” said Ginny, and pointed at the far booth.

He looked. It was a wall: red plaster, a little damp. Then it was not. For about two seconds it went transparent, the way water does when a shadow leaves it, and behind it was a room.

He had known the room before it came. A low ceiling. A lamp with a green shade. A desk made of a door on two trestles, the left one split. Paper everywhere, not stacked but *drifted*. A cup with a ring under it. A chair pushed back, and nobody in it.

Then the plaster was a wall again, and the wet had gone out of it.

“Nine times a night,” said Ginny. “Two seconds a go. Once a month it shows something else, and that’s the something else. Describe it.”

He did, and was careful not to say anything that could be taken for more than a description.

“And a typewriter,” Ginny finished for him. “That’s your desk, isn’t it. I’ve been looking at your desk through my back wall once a month for eleven years.” She watched him. “It ran four seconds until four o’clock this morning. It has run two ever since. Whatever’s on the other side has learned to keep it short. A glance. Like a man afraid of being caught looking.”

She took a card from the inside pocket of her jacket, cream-coloured, stamped with four lobes in violet, and held it up between two fingers without letting him read it.

“I don’t own this place. Nobody here owns anything. Instructions arrive on cards. For eleven years they’ve described one man: a tall man in a coat, with a cane with an onion on it, and what to do if he walks in the front. *Let him in. Let him look. Do not stop him. Do not help him.*” She said the last four words as though they had a taste. “I’ve followed it to the letter. I want you to know I didn’t like it.”

“I know.”

“Do you?”

“You gave me the corridor,” said Oliver. “Anyone can give a man a corridor. You told me what I was doing with my feet.”

That seemed to land. Ginny looked at the card, and at him, and put it away. “This week,” she said, in a different voice, “the Insta-gators had a card I wasn’t shown.”

At the bar the three alligators did not move. The largest of them turned a slow eye on Ginny, and then on Oliver, like a lamp being turned down. Then he took a card from his breast pocket and laid it on the bar with one claw, face up.

It was cream-coloured, stamped, in the same hand as all the others, but pressing differently: the letters had gone down into the stock as though the writer had held the pen a fraction longer on every stroke. It said: *IF HE ASKS, HELP HIM.*

Ginny read it. She read it again. Her hands, which had not moved all evening, went to her hair and pinned it tighter, which is a thing people do with their hands when their faces have had enough.

“Eleven years,” she said. “Same hand, same instruction. And now this.” She looked at Oliver. “Somebody’s changed his mind.”

She showed him the ice machine behind the bar, as if it were the last of the evidence. The drain ran uphill for eleven inches.

“That pipe was straight in March. I had it in. I watched him fit it. It ran downhill because pipes do. So my building has been quietly redecorating the plumbing, and the only reason anybody knows is that ice is the one thing in here that won’t lie about which way is down.”

At the door she stopped him with a hand flat on his chest, the way you stop a man at the edge of a platform.

“Guard up, Onions. Whatever you’re walking toward, it’s going to end in a room with one other person in it. They always do. And in a room with one other person, authority isn’t the loud thing. It’s whoever’s still there at the end of the sentence.” She took the hand away. “Be there at the end of the sentence.”

8 · Rest Assured

Rest Assured was a funeral parlour at the sharp end of the parish, where the lampposts gave up and the street went on without them. It was low and long and built of dark obsidian that gave back the lamplight in a single wet line, and its door stood open at all hours, and on the step, in brass letters set into the stone, someone had written MIND THE. The stone ran out there. The word it was waiting for was presumably *step*, or *gap*, or *threshold*; it had been left for visitors to supply.

“You have come to the house of the horizontal,” said a voice from the dark, “which is the only house in Silvora Reefs where nobody has ever complained about the stairs.”

She came out of the gloom like something that had been put away carefully and brought out for the occasion. Hannah O’Dochtaigh, called Soliloquy by those who liked her and by those who didn’t, was tall and gaunt and dressed in black like a formal occasion, with a pallor that did not seem to be a choice, teeth she kept behind her lips like a promise, and a face designed for pronouncements. She was the keeper of the vaults. She spoke in riddles and puns and in speeches addressed, with great politeness, to nobody.

“Welcome to Rest Assured, Mr Onions,” she said, “where the departed find their peace and pieces of the living sometimes find their rest. How may I assist your… final arrangements?”

“Mind the threshold,” she said. “It is the only part of my establishment that has ever asked anything of anybody, and what it asks is very small: that you notice which way you are going through it.”

She walked him along the east corridor, which ran on a good deal further than the building it was in. It was lined on both sides with vaults, each fronted by a small brass plate, and as they passed, the plates carried his name. *OLIVER ONIONS.* Plate after plate, and on the fourth, a middle name no one in this town had any business knowing. He had not said it aloud in thirty years.

“The dead are accommodating,” said Soliloquy, as they passed. “Who lies in a vault depends upon who is looking, and when. The sailor you would have seen at noon is a schoolmistress by dusk. It is very restful for them.”

“Everyone sees their own name,” said Soliloquy. “It is a mirror, Mr Onions. A brass one. Mirrors are not clever. They are only very, very attentive.”

“A mirror doesn’t know a middle name I haven’t said aloud in thirty years.”

The rhyme went out of her face. “No,” she said. “It does not.”

She stood quite still. When she spoke again it was without any music.

“The plates do not reflect the reader. They show whatever name is currently being written. Yours, only while you are looking.” She turned to the nearest vault. “I thought it a mirror all my life. It is a *page.*”

She stopped outside the first of the plated doors and put one hand flat on it, as one might on the flank of a horse.

“Forty of my vaults were paid for in advance. By the Coalition. Forty people who described the impossible things this town does, aloud, in company, again and again, in the plain way you or I might say *it is raining.* A card came for each of them. And then they came to me.”

“And then they died.”

“And then they *came to me,*” said Soliloquy. “It is a distinction I have not found comforting, but it is the one I was given. Saying a thing aloud in Silvora Reefs is how a thing gets to be the case. It is the local physics. It is why Bud Onkuhdonk holds up the Outside Inn with his mouth. It is why nobody will tell you about the rotors. The Coalition are clerks, Mr Onions. They arrive afterwards, with forms.” She looked at him. “You have been telling people things.”

“Small things.”

“Small things are how it starts. Forty of them, and every one told somebody. Not out of foolishness. Out of *relief.* It is an unbearable amount to carry alone, and the carrying is the whole of the price.”

“Darek says I shouldn’t do it alone.”

“Darek is a counter. He says what he counts.” She was not unkind. “I say that a thing carried a little while, until you know what you want to be true, is a thing that cannot be made true by accident. Carry it a while longer. It is worth what it costs.”

Two people had told him, in the same evening, opposite things, and he had the uneasy sense that both of them were right.

“Then I’ll keep it,” he said. “All of it. Until I know what I want to be true.”

“Then you are the first,” said Soliloquy, and for a moment she looked ten years younger and very frightened.

At the end of the west corridor was a vault with no plate. Its door stood ajar by the width of two fingers, and out of the gap came the cool of stone and a smell, very faint, of kitchen: bread, and a draught, and a woman who had only just left the room.

“Mrs Ahearne’s,” said Soliloquy. “So I call it. It has never had provision for a plate. It stands ajar because it was left ajar, by somebody who meant to come straight back, and has not, and the width has not changed in eleven years. I measure it every Michaelmas. It is the only measurement in this town that has never once disagreed with itself.” She did not look at the door. “I keep it shut. By which I mean I keep it exactly as open as it is.”

Oliver put out a hand. He found that he could not touch the door. He found, further, that he was not afraid of it, only of the manner in which it would be opened.

“When you find the room,” said Soliloquy behind him, in the voice of a woman reading out a will, “look at the *page.* Not the desk. Not the lamp. The page. And whatever is on it, do not read it aloud.”

He walked home through a parish whose clocks disagreed with one another by hours. His own watch said 3:33 and did not mind.

9 · Cheeses Thrice

In the morning the map was gone.

The notebook in his coat held two pages where there had been three. Where the map had been was a clean dry leaf with a faint depression in it, the memory of a pen pressing, and he sat on the edge of the bed and understood two things in quick succession. The first was that something was being taken back, and that it was being taken in order. The second was that he could still see the map perfectly: the harbour, the lamps, the X, *THEN WHAT?*, every line of it. He had lost the page and kept the thing it said. He did not find this reassuring.

He went out into the long violet morning, with the elephant at his shoulder and nothing in his stomach, and followed the parish to its pizzeria, because he was hungry and there was a light on.

Cheeses Thrice Pizza stood on the corner of Mercy and Vesper with its door propped open on a wedge of something that was probably cheese. Behind the counter, a bull antelope in a stained apron was fussing over a pizza peel. He was a large, anxious animal

with a pelt like thick wool and a pair of antlers that went the wrong way, forward and down, as though the head were trying to dig. His name was Woolbinkle. He saw Oliver and put the peel down with an air of acute relief.

“Welcome to Cheeses Thrice! Our three-cheese blend is absolutely perfect today, I can feel it’s going to make exactly what you need! Mr Onions! I had a feeling. I had a feeling and I put one on, and if I was wrong I’d have eaten it myself, so there’s no—there’s no obligation, is what I’m saying.”

The pizza came out of the oven already cut. The cheese, as it melted, did not spread as cheese does; it ran into lines, and the lines into rows, and for a moment it lay across the crust in a pattern like a manuscript page: faint script in an even hand. Oliver did not read it. He had been told not to read things aloud and had decided, on his own account, not to read things at all.

“Your thoughts,” said Woolbinkle, peering, “are particularly spicy today.”

In the corner booth a clown in a faded costume was telling a joke to a table nobody was sitting at. “Why did the pizza cross the road? Because… um… it was cheesy? Get it? Cheesy? No? Well, how about this one…” Chuckles the Unfunny had been at it for as long as the pizzeria had been open, and had never once been laughed at on purpose. By the door, a thin man in a pressed grey suit was making notes on a clipboard. “According to municipal code 47.3-B,” said Antopolis Ficklefuk, Health Inspector, to nobody in particular, “this establishment demonstrates irregular compliance with standard operational parameters. I shall document these… inconsistencies.” He had come every Tuesday for years, Woolbinkle whispered, and had never once eaten.

A shelf ran the length of the back wall, and the shelf was cans. They stood in ranks, with paper labels in a neat, anxious hand: *Patience. March. Mrs Pell’s Laugh. The Day the Ferry Was Late.*

“I can things,” said Woolbinkle, who had followed his eye. “Something happens, and it’s got a shape, and if you leave it out it goes off. Or worse, it goes *vague*. Vague’s worse than off. You can throw off away. So I get it in a can while it’s still got its shape.” He drew himself up. “Everything here goes vague, Mr Onions. Menus. Hallways. How many vaults there are. But these hold. All the years I’ve been at it, not one of them’s gone.”

He showed Oliver the last can on the shelf. It was dented and old and its label had been turned to the wall. He turned it round himself, with the care you take with a thing that bites. *CAN’T ELOPE, ANTELOPE*, it said, and underneath, smaller, in a hand Oliver knew: *a poem by O. Onions.*

“It’s about the worst thing I ever did,” said Woolbinkle. “I asked a woman to elope, once, on the pier. She said she would, the day I could can-can, and I have two left feet and four hooves. I took it badly. I took her home and I cooked her, with cantaloupe, and I would like it noted that I have been strictly vegetarian since. You wrote it up the winter after, Mr Onions, so the parish could have it by heart. The poem has her say no. She never said no. She said *not yet.* And it came out of your pen as *nope*, for the rhyme, and it is a better rhyme, and I have spent eleven years coming to terms with the fact that it’s a better rhyme.” He was not angry. He had gone past anger into the flat country where a man files things. “I remember it both ways. That’s the trouble with a can. It keeps what you put in. It doesn’t say which was true.”

“I wrote *that*?” said Oliver.

“It’s your hand on the can,” said Woolbinkle, kindly. “Everybody asks.”

“She said *not yet,*” said Oliver.

He heard himself say it, in a voice, in a room, where it could be heard.

Nothing dramatic happened. In Woolbinkle’s hands the can made a small sound, like a held breath let go, and its label changed. The ink ran, and thought better of it, and settled: *NOT YET, ANTELOPE.*

“That doesn’t rhyme,” said Woolbinkle, after a time.

“No.”

“It’s a much worse rhyme.”

“It’s what she said.”

The antelope held the can against his apron with both forelegs and did not seem able to speak. Oliver stood very still, with the cold knowledge of how little it had taken. He had said one small true thing aloud, and the room had altered to fit it. *Carry it a while longer,* Soliloquy had said. He understood now what she had been afraid of, and that it had nothing to do with the big things.

“I’m nobody, you know,” said Woolbinkle presently, to the can. “I’m the fella who does the cheese.”

“You are not nobody.”

The lights came up by about a quarter. The far wall came in three feet. The room, which had been the temperature of a larder, became the temperature of a kitchen with someone in it.

“If *I* can make something in this town that holds,” Woolbinkle said, in a shaking voice, “then holding is possible here, Mr Onions. And if holding is possible, then somebody has been choosing not to.” He wiped his eyes with the back of a hoof. “I’ve had a lot of things given back to me over the years. Given back is a whole category and I know it well. I’ve never had one *left* with me.”

10 · Giddyup End ’Em Ribs

Giddyup End ’Em Ribs was a long low room that smelled of woodsmoke and old argument, with a single table running the length of it. The table was twenty-two feet long, scarred and black and polished by two generations of elbows, and at the exact middle of it sat an old man with both palms flat on the wood.

A man from the university had once carbon-dated the roof beams, and the results had come back as three different centuries and an apology.

Wutchu Uptu, Ben to the whole of Silvora Reefs, was eighty-eight, and had not, to anyone’s knowledge, stood up since the Coalition was founded. He did not look at the door. He looked at Oliver’s boots, and then at the left shoulder of Oliver’s coat, and then, without any hurry, at nothing in particular, which was where he did his best work.

“What you been up to, my friend,” said Ben, “that you ain’t told nobody? Come on in, sit yourself down. I got ribs here’ll remind you what good eating’s about.”

“Nothing,” said Oliver.

“Mm.” The palms did not move. “Sit.”

At the far end of the table a man in a deerstalker was examining a rib through a magnifying glass. “Elementary!” said Sherlock Schidt. “The evidence clearly indicates that the solution lies in… well. Let us simply say the bowel movements of the situation.”

“Schidt,” said Ben, without turning his head, “eat your ribs.”

The walls were hung with masks. There were hundreds of them, carved and moulded in a tribal style no scholar had ever been able to place, in wood and plaster and papier-mâché, each on its own nail, and every one was a face Oliver knew: Darek’s, Ginny’s, Landy’s with its dreadful smile, Soliloquy’s hollow-cheeked pronouncement. They arrived on the step in the morning, said Ben, unwrapped and unlabelled, always the likeness of a living Reefer. He hung every one. A person with a mask on the wall got a little more real for it. It was when they stopped arriving that you worried.

“There’s one come thirty years ago,” said Ben, “and it come wrong.”

He nodded at the far wall. Behind the fisherman's mask, half hidden, hung one more: a long face, deep-set at the eyes, with a mouth very slightly too wide, painted in violet and green. There was no place for it on the wall, because nobody in Silvora Reefs had that face. "Held it in the doorway two hours before I put it up. Been not-decidin' about it ever since."

Oliver looked at it a long while. It was his face. It was not his face. Everything in it had been moved a sixteenth of an inch toward the way a mirror would have it, and stopped short.

"Under the table," said Ben.

Oliver bent, one hand on his bad knee. The underside of the board was carved from end to end with initials: nineteen sets, each with a number beside it, cut with a penknife and worn down over the years to a dash. A twentieth place had been left at the end, and the wood there had been kept clean for as long as the table had stood. It was not clean now. *O.O.*, said the wood, new-cut and pale, and beside it a numeral. The numeral was II.

"The number only goes one way," said Ben, above him. "When it gets small, the person starts comin' in more. Sits with me. Don't say why. Don't have to."

Oliver straightened. His hand, on the table, was not entirely steady, and Ben's palm was a foot away from it, not touching, which seemed to be the old man's idea of holding a hand.

"What's it like?" said Oliver. "Remembering things that aren't yours."

"It ain't knowin'," said Ben. "It's *rememberin'*. I remember your mother at a table with her back to a door. I remember it the way I remember my own weddin', and I wasn't at neither. About a third of what I've got ain't mine, and I have never in my life been able to tell you which third."

"My mother," said Oliver.

"Woman at a table with her back to a door," said Ben. "Lookin' at you over her shoulder. Says: *And furthermore*—"

The sound that left Oliver was not a word. At his shoulder something very large went perfectly still.

"In *your* voice," said Ben. His palms came up off the table. In fifty years they had not come off that table for anything short of a funeral, and they hung there now a hand's breadth above the wood, trembling very slightly, like a man who has felt a floor move. "She said it in your voice. It ain't mine, Ols. It's yours."

Oliver did not remember. He had a name for an elephant and the shape of a sentence that someone had begun, and nothing whatever to put the rest of it on. He sat down at the twentieth place, and Ben put his hands back on the table, and neither of them said

anything for a long time. It was the first time in two days that he had been in a room with someone who knew what he was afraid of and had not tried to fix it.

11 · Outside In

The Outside Inn was a hotel that had been turned inside out and put back in the wrong order, so that its lobby had weather. A small, definite sky hung under the plaster, grey at the edges, with a fine rain falling in the corner by the desk and a stream running between the sofas under a bridge someone had had the decency to paint, with a waterfall at the far end. Trees grew from the carpet. The proprietor, Josh 'Barney' Arneaux, a robust man in his forties with a weathered face and rustic-elegant clothes, conducted all of it from behind the reception counter with the warm, unhurried air of someone about to tell you a story.

"Welcome to the Outside Inn!" said Barney. "You'll find the weather inside is particularly lovely today. Got some fresh snow falling in the east wing and sunshine by the waterfall. Don't touch the stream, though. It's on a schedule, and it holds a grudge. Did I ever tell you about the winter it flooded the dining room?"

Bud Onkuhdonk, the bellhop, came across the lobby at a trot. He was a big man in a small cap, and he began every sentence with a word that had been put there to hold a building up.

"BUT—before you say anything—everything in this establishment is completely normal and I'd thank you to note that I said it first."

"I haven't said anything."

"BUT you were about to." Bud said it the way one holds a door against wind. Then, lower, behind his hand, with his eyes fixed on the ceiling: "BUT it's a light well. The thing in the roof. It's a light well. It's always been a light well."

Soliloquy had said that this was how the building stood: that Bud said it every morning and the Inn went on being an inn. Oliver, who had a notebook with two pages left in it and a good deal of sympathy for any man holding up a roof with his mouth, said, "It's a lovely light well." Bud's shoulders came down by an inch.

There were two guests by the stream. One was standing, narrow, in a good coat, with a hand raised to the rain. The other was sitting by the stair, narrow, in the same coat, with the other hand raised. They were not twins. When one moved his hand the other moved his opposite, in perfect time, without looking at one another, and neither seemed aware of the arrangement.

“Dee Stroii,” said Barney, as though it were a single name. “A guest, or two. Don’t ask which is the first.”

Oliver lifted the monocle, found he did not want to, and put it down. He did not ask which was the first.

The street between the Inn and the barber’s was the best street in the parish, and he took it slowly, because he had begun to understand that he was not walking through a town but being introduced to one.

At Chef D.’s Lishush Mush, where every dish on the board had been designed with an eye to the dentally challenged, a toothless old woman with a face like a warm loaf leaned out of the kitchen window and passed him a spoon. “Ah, vhat a lovely day for thome lithuth muth!” said Chef Delilah Rishrush. “You look like you need thomething comforting.” He did, and it did: pale, soft, uniform, entirely without edges, and tasting impossibly of a Tuesday. Behind her the sous chef, T., was declaiming to a pan with the whole of his body. “Behold! Tonight we shall create not mere sustenance, but edible poetry!” The pan said *shhhk.* A ladle drifted off the counter and was caught.

Across from the police headquarters, Dude’s Dews & Don’ts had changed its rules again since the morning. A sign in the window said that today you must ask for what you wanted by describing the colour of your feelings, and Mary Guana, bloodshot and amiable, slow as a lizard on a warm stone, explained this from behind the till. “Dude… today’s rules are… well. Don’t worry about it.” By the donut case a large, contemplative man held a glazed one up to the light. “You see, the donut represents the circle of existence, man,” said Fatty McFatterton. “Empty in the middle but sweet all around.”

And down the middle of the road, with the patience of geology, a municipal waste truck was proceeding at the speed of a thought being finished. “Heyyy… there… buddy,” said Jayse Hayste, through the window, as it passed, “I’m… just… gonna… need… about… seventeen… more… minutes.” Oliver was still waving when the truck reached the corner. It would be some time before it left it.

12 · The G.’s Spot

The barbershop was called the G.’s Spot, a name chosen long ago for reasons the proprietor had stopped explaining. It was difficult to find unless you already knew where it was; the lesbians of the parish always did, and had never once been wrong. It had four chairs, four mirrors, and a floor of black-and-white tile that had been swept so long it had grown hollow. The proprietor was Antonio ‘Tony’ Vino, who had been a performer once and

still went by Wino-T, and who moved to a rhythm nobody else could hear, every pass of the clippers falling on the beat. He had a gold tooth and a very still face, and he answered most questions with the same two words.

“Why not settle in, my friend?” said Wino-T, to the beat, when Oliver asked whether he had time for a trim. “We’ll get you cleaned up nice, every snip in perfect time. Why not trust the process?”

The mirrors did not agree about what they were reflecting. In the first, the shop was perfectly accurate, except that the clock on the wall ran backwards. In the second there was a street in the rain, a street that was not outside. In the third was an owlbear.

Sir Jerry, who did the cutting, was a barber-surgeon of the old school, in a tabard over scrubs, with a razor in one hand and a very serious expression. He sat Oliver in the second chair and addressed his scalp.

“Good morrow, noble patron! Thy tresses require the ministrations of both blade and wisdom. Lo, the presenting field is lightly cropped,” said Sir Jerry. “Prognosis favourable. We shall proceed with a *gentle* debridement of the sideburn.”

Oliver looked into the mirror for his own face and was shown, instead, a man at a desk. He had his back to the glass. He was typing. His shoulders had the look of shoulders that had been in that position a very long time.

“You may find the glass unreliable,” said Wino-T. “Why not?”

In the third mirror, something very large shifted. It had a bear’s body and an owl’s head, and it wore a tailcoat, and it stood among the barber’s chairs with its wings folded and its human hands folded in front of it. When it spoke, it was in a French accent that rolled its r’s like marbles across a polished floor, in the voice of an aristocrat who had been well brought up a very long time ago, with the faint, patient edge of a creature that could afford to be gentle.

“Ah, bonjour, mon ami. Monsieur Onions. Do forgive ze formality of ze arrangement. I should come out. I find I am unable. Such interesting conversations one overhears in zis establishment, non?”

Oliver got up (Sir Jerry, with great dignity, paused) and crossed the shop to the third mirror. On the way he passed through the empty air between the chairs, and the temperature was wrong on the far side. It was not cold. It was *later.* He came out into a room that had been going on a few seconds longer than the one he left.

“How long have you been in the mirror?”

“Longer than the shop,” said Albert. “I recall being *in the room* for that, monsieur, and standing on the boards, and being handed a cup.”

“You were in the room.”

“I was mentioned less. Then only in passing. Then as a feature rather than a patron. At each stage I was a little further into the glass. One cannot lodge a complaint about a diminution in mentions; there is no office.” The great owl’s head tilted. “You are being mentioned a very great deal at present, monsieur. In this shop, at the Inn, at the mausoleum, in the pizzeria. A man who is mentioned a great deal is a man who is *in* the room. But mentions may be withdrawn. That is the whole of my counsel. They may be withdrawn, and there is no office, and it does not hurt.”

Oliver laid his hand against the glass. It was cold, and it was not quite glass. “Why only in the mirror?”

“Because the glass will have me. A mirror does not select, monsieur. The room has *taste.*” He said it without bitterness, as a man reports the weather.

The mirror, had it been asked, would have said that he was good company, and the only thing in the shop that had ever said thank you to a surface; that he had been getting quieter for years; that it could not make him louder, only refuse to stop including him; and that it never once had.

“What have you seen?” said Oliver.

“From in here, he is not at a desk in another room. He is in *this* one. At a desk in the middle of the shop, between the chairs, where there is no desk. Antonio walks through the place where the desk is forty times a day and has never once broken stride.”

“Could you ask him to turn round?”

Albert faced the gap between the chairs and addressed it with great courtesy, in the voice of a man at a dinner party. “Sir. There is a gentleman here who would like a word.”

In the second mirror, the man at the desk stopped.

For four full seconds the room that had been typing for a fortnight did not type. In the shop the clock ran backwards into the silence. Even Sir Jerry held his razor still. Then the keys began again, faster, and did not stop.

“He heard,” said Albert, and for the first time the courtesy cracked and something warm and astonished came through. “All my years of being a feature, and it transpires the whole apparatus can be interrupted by an owlbear being *polite* at the correct piece of empty air.

I shall be doing that again. Every evening, at six. It is not much of a campaign. It is, however, entirely mine."

That night the notebook in Oliver's coat was warm against his ribs, like something asleep, and he lay a long time and listened to a page being turned, and did not say what it was.

Part Three — The Gaps

13 · The Coalition

On the third morning the letter was gone.

Dear Furthermore, it had said, and stopped, and in the night the nib had come for it, and the second dry page was a clean leaf with the ghost of a pen on it. One page remained: the list. Nine names ruled through, and two lines at the bottom that had been blank when he first saw them. They were still blank. He looked at them for some time before he understood that they were not empty. They were waiting.

He did not need the penknife on Ben's table to tell him what the number was.

He did what, he was beginning to suspect, he did for a living, and followed the paperwork. The four-lobed seal had been on every form he had seen, and he followed it, the way one follows a smell, down the hill and along Vesper Street to a narrow door between the post office and a shuttered optician's. On the door was a brass plate. THE COALITION FOR CULPABILITY AND CONSTRUCTIVE CHANGE (QUAD-C). ENQUIRIES BY APPOINTMENT. NO APPOINTMENTS ARE AVAILABLE.

He went in.

The Coalition occupied one long grey room with a great many desks in it, all of them empty and all of them dusted. At the far end sat the only person in the building. He was a small, neat man in a suit so good that it seemed to have been left to stand up on its own, and he was copying something by hand onto a printed form, with a steel pen, in a hand considerably better than Landy's. He did not look up.

"Name?"

"Onions."

"Fault?"

"I'm not here to report one."

"Everyone is, sir," said the clerk, writing. "They have simply not been told."

The nameplate on his desk said CALLOWAY QUINT, CLERK (SECOND CLASS). Beside him lay a stamp pad and two stamps. One said RESOLVED and was black to the handle with use. The other said WITHDRAWN and was almost clean.

“How many times have you used that one?” said Oliver.

Quint’s pen did not hesitate. “Forty.”

“Did you know them?”

“They are files, sir.” He said it quickly, the way a man says a thing he has said to himself in the small hours. “I file. I do not read. It is a point of professional honour.”

On the wall behind him was a brass plate, hand-cut, the letters wandering a little, as though the engraver had been tired or moved. *O.R.A.C.L.E.*, it said. *OPERANT REALITY ALTERATION AND CAUSALITY LINKING ENGINE. ACTIVATION UPON EXHAUSTION.* Beneath it was a dial behind glass, with a single numeral showing. The numeral was I.

“It was blank,” said Quint, following his eye, “for as long as I have been here. Three days ago it said III. Yesterday, II. I wrote to the relevant department. There is no relevant department.” He set his pen down very precisely, parallel to the edge of the form. “The plate says *activation upon exhaustion.* I have been assuming it meant me.”

That was, Oliver thought, the saddest thing anyone in the parish had told him, and it had been said by a man in perfect trim, at a desk, with a clean pen.

“What are you copying, Mr Quint?”

“Maintenance.”

“Would you read it to me?”

“I do not read, sir.”

“Your pen has run out,” said Oliver.

It was a small thing. He said it quite gently, in a voice, in a room, where it could be heard; and the pen, which had been full, was dry. Quint picked it up. He drew it across a spare sheet and nothing came. He stared at it, and at his hand, and for the first time in some eleven years he read what was in front of him.

The master form was pinned beside the desk. He copied from it every day. He read it aloud now in a voice with no air in it.

“*Nature of fault: structural, longstanding, load-bearing. Remedy: none available.*” He stopped. “*Recommend company.*”

“That is what you have been sending the parish,” said Oliver. “Twenty-two forms to one hanging building, and the rest to the rest. *Recommend company.* And it goes out stamped *no further action is available to the resident.*”

“I thought it was a form of words.”

“It’s a prescription.”

Quint looked at the stamp that said WITHDRAWN. He did not pick it up. He moved it, with one finger, to the very edge of the desk, where it sat half off, like something that might fall.

“I shall have to think about my stamp, sir,” he said.

“That’s all I’d ask.”

The cards came, he explained, from a slot in the wall, lined with felt, into a wire tray; he had never seen from where. They had always come in the same weight of hand. “Until a few days ago. Since then they have come heavier. As if whoever wrote them had stopped being sure.” He walked Oliver to the door, a thing he had never done, and stood there uncertainly in his good suit.

“Mr Onions. When it says one, and then—what is after one?”

Oliver said that he would let him know, if he could, and found, to his surprise, that he meant it.

Part Four — The Office

14 · The Seam

He went to Durry Kwain at dusk.

Darek was behind the counter, wiping a clean surface, and he had Oliver’s order across it before the bell had finished. Oliver put his hand on the cone and did not pick it up.

“Walk me home,” he said.

Darek looked at him for a good while. Then he took off his apron, and folded it, and put it under the counter, and turned the sign in the window to CLOSED, which, as far as anyone on the hill could have testified, he had never done. “Well, now,” he said, and fetched his hat.

They walked up between the green lamps. Darek walked as he talked, a beat ahead, so that he reached each lamppost slightly before its shadow did. At the foot of the Hang-hai stair Oliver told him, in plain words and without any of the large ones, where he was going: that he was going through the glass at the end of his corridor; that he did not know who would come out; that he was not asking leave. Darek heard it all with his hat in both hands.

“Sure,” said Darek. “I’ll be on the stair.”

“It might be a long time.”

“I’m a touch ahead of everybody,” said Darek. “I got nowhere to be but later.”

They climbed. On the second floor Oliver stopped at the head of the stair and looked down his corridor, and counted it, for the first time, with someone beside him. It was eleven feet. It ran eleven feet from the stair to his door, with a coat-rack and a green flame in a bracket and his own door at the end of it, and nothing about it was any trouble at all.

“Told you,” said Darek, very low.

At the door Oliver put out his hand, and Darek took it, and they stood for a moment with the handshake going on a little longer than a handshake does. Then Darek went back to the head of the stair and sat down on the top step with his hat on his knee, like a man waiting for a bus in which he has absolute faith.

The tall spotted glass hung where it always hung. Oliver stood in front of it and held still, and the mirror, which had been plaguing him for three days with its offers, stopped bothering. It showed him the edge between them: a band about four inches wide, with no thickness at all, where the corridor ended and a room began. The office was on the other side of it. The lamp was on. The chair was pushed back. A page stood in the machine with type on it. Nothing was stopping him.

At his left shoulder something large and soft and purple stood patiently, with a saddle on its back that nobody had ever sat in.

He stepped through.

There was no membrane. There was no cold, and no drama. His corridor was behind him, the coat-rack, the green flame, eleven years of coming home, and then it was not. The last thing he heard of it was a bucket being set down two floors below and a squeegee beginning its arc.

He was standing on boards in a room nine feet by eleven. The floor was the same floor, the same width of board and the same grain, running under the frame without a join. A green-shaded lamp lit a desk made of a door on two trestles, the left one split. A chair was

pushed back. A wire basket stood beside it, spilling paper across the boards. A cup with a ring under it sat at the corner of the desk, and the ring was older than the cup. And on the desk, black and low and squat, sat a typewriter with a brass plate on its frame, rubbed smooth by thumbs, and a small round dial on its carriage that said I.

A man stood at the wall with his back to Oliver. He did not turn round. He did not appear surprised.

Then he turned, and it was Oliver's own face.

Not a resemblance. His face, with everything in it moved a sixteenth of an inch toward the mirror image and stopped short.

"Well," said the man. "Now we have both had a very long day."

15 · The Argument

He said it in Oliver's own voice, tired and dry and a little rueful, but the voice came from a throat that had been used differently, and it ended every sentence a fraction lower than Oliver would have. He wore a green tailcoat with purple facings, Oliver's own turned inside out, the colour of the lampshade. There was ink on his hands to the wrist. He gestured at the second chair, and Oliver sat, because in a room that size there was nowhere else a person could.

"Eleven years," said Revilo, "I have kept a chair in a room nine feet by eleven in which there is no reason whatever for there to be two chairs. Every visitor I have ever had has been me, coming in and sitting in the other one." He lowered himself into the first. "Say your name."

"You know it."

"I know it. I should like to hear it."

"Oliver Onions." And then, because it was the thing he had been trying to say since he first heard it in Darek's mouth: "Snoino Revilo."

"Letter for letter. Both ways." Something eased in the long face. "Not an anagram. An anagram is a coincidence with good manners. A reversal is an *author.* Silvo and Ovlis founded this town twice, eleven years apart, on the same plots, and neither charter mentions the other. That was not cleverness. That was a man who could not settle on a name and had not the discipline to throw the first away, and the parish has been living in both ever since. I have never thrown anything away. You will have noticed the basket."

He nodded at it. It was a wire basket, overflowing, and the drift of crumpled paper went on across the floor beneath the desk. Oliver did not need to smooth the balls and read them. He knew what they said. They said him.

“You’ve been writing me,” said Oliver.

“I have been writing you. Yes.” Revilo said it quite simply, like a man setting down a very heavy parcel he has carried a long way. “*You are not a man.* You are a draft. You are the best thing I have ever done, and I have done nothing else. You are two hundred pages and a set of habits and a stopped watch. When you tell me you are frightened, what is happening is that I have written down that you are frightened. There is no fact underneath you. I have looked. I built the looking.”

“Yes,” said Oliver. “And so are you.”

Revilo stopped.

It was four full seconds, by the watch in Oliver’s pocket, which for once seemed to be keeping time.

“Go on,” said Revilo.

“You stand at a window that’s a wall. You keep a chair for a visitor who is yourself. You have a cup with a ring under it older than the cup, and you have never once left this room to get another, because there’s no *out there* for you to get one in. You’re nine feet by eleven and a set of habits. And when I came through that seam your sentence stopped in the middle, because the writing of a man and the being of him can’t happen in the same second.” He drew a breath. “One of us is standing in a room he can leave.”

Revilo looked at the page in the machine. “That is the argument I have been unable to write down for eleven years,” he said, “and you have made it in a room with no window, on a knee that has been going since March. I would like it on record that I am not angry. I have simply been beaten with my own vocabulary and there is nobody to complain to.”

He almost smiled. It did not take.

“The others,” said Oliver. “They have insides. I’ve been in them.”

“I did not put insides in them.”

“No. They grew them. In the gaps. While you were busy.” He counted them off, as one counts what has been saved from a fire. “Albert was mentioned less, a little at a time, until he was in a mirror, and he has been courteous about it ever since. Dee Stroii was described, and the description stopped, and started again better, and the first one was

left in. Not by accident. By someone who couldn't take it out. Bud says *it's a light well* every morning because the one year he didn't, a floor went. Woolbinkle cans the things you wouldn't let him keep." He paused. "You changed a woman's answer for a rhyme."

The writer's face did something quiet and terrible. "I did," he said. "*Not yet* to *nope.* It scanned."

"I put it back."

"I know. I felt it." Revilo's hand lay open on the desk. "Yesterday morning. The days have stopped being separate. I was in the middle of a sentence about a stair, and something went through the whole draft like a dropped plate. Somebody had said a thing that I could not unwrite. I looked up, and the page was perfectly intact, and I understood what I had built." He looked at Oliver with something like awe. "I can write. You can *say.* I wrote the local physics, and I did not grasp until a pizzeria that I had given you the one thing I cannot take back."

"The forty," said Oliver.

"Yes." It was a very small word. "I did not kill them. I stopped describing them. It is the same thing, and I have never found the difference comforting. They had begun to say it to one another, you see, aloud, in the plain voice, and every sentence they said was a sentence I had not written and could not revise, and I was afraid. I made a Coalition out of fear and gave it a clerk and a stamp. It was the best-run institution I ever imagined, and the clerk never knew what he was copying. There was never any malice in it. That is the worst of it; I should be easier to forgive if there had been."

"He knows now. He's put the stamp down."

Revilo shut his eyes briefly. "Did he," he said. It was the first time in eleven years that anything had come back to him from the town that he had not predicted, and it plainly hurt and plainly delighted him. "Did he."

Oliver took the notebook out and laid it open on the desk. The last dry page lay between them. *Olivier d'Oignon. Ollie Onyon. Oswin Unyan.*

"Nine men," said Revilo. "I wrote nine men to stand where you stand, and each one got as far as the harbour and no further, because I could not write the walk. A man needs somewhere to go, and I could not make myself decide where. You are the first I could write walking. That is the only difference between you and them." He touched the ruled lines, not quite touching. "I am sorry about the nine. I have never said so aloud."

"It's true now," said Oliver, gently.

“So it is.”

“The ink,” said Oliver. “The pages.”

“There is not enough for two. There was never going to be.” Revilo laid a hand on the typewriter. “I have been drawing it back, page by page, out of what I had already spent, in order to spend it again. I used to think it was thrift. I believe it is called cannibalism. This is the engine. I named it in a better year.” He turned the brass plate with a thumb. The dial on the carriage said I. “It counts what is left. When the last page comes home the ribbon is dry, and whatever sentence is in the machine is the last sentence there will ever be.”

“There’s a vault,” said Oliver. “With no plate.”

“I know the vault.”

“There’s a woman at a table with her back to a door.” It was not a sentence he could say with any steadiness. “Ben remembers her. In my voice.”

Revilo did not move. “I called her Ahearne,” he said, “because I could not write her name. It is the nearest name that would hold. She was an actress and a painter, and she began speeches she was not sure how to end and trusted the room to finish them for her. She was at a kitchen table in a house I have never succeeded in describing, with her back to the door, telling you something, and your father was in the car outside with the engine running, and she did not finish. *And furthermore*— She turned at the sound of the horn, and got up, and left the door ajar, to come straight back. They did not. You were eighteen. You were watching the door.” His mouth worked. “I have been trying to write the next line for twenty-six years. The vault has stood open by the width of that line ever since.”

Oliver said nothing. He did not trust anything he might have said.

“The page,” said Revilo. “You were told to look at the page.”

He looked. He read it silently, twice, as he had been warned, in a small black type that leaned toward him.

…he stepped through the glass, and sat in the second chair, and looked at the man at the desk, and he does not

It stopped there. There was no full stop. The carriage waited at the margin, the way a person waits who has asked a question.

“It is the sentence in which you arrive,” said Revilo. “*He looked at the man at the desk, and he does not.* Recognise me. Forgive me. Leave. Say anything at all. I do not know what he does not, because the man is real, and I cannot write what a real man does; he does it. I have typed *does not* two hundred times, and the next word is in the basket by your foot,

and every one is different, and every one is wrong." He put both hands flat on the desk. "One of us has to finish it. It cannot be finished by both, and it cannot be left, because a sentence left in the present continuous does not stay still. It frays. Whoever finishes it keeps the language. The other becomes something that has been described. I am not going to advise you. Take the chair or don't."

At Oliver's shoulder the air changed.

Something very large, which had been standing against the wall of that small room ever since the seam, with an unused saddle and the whole of its patience, drew itself up.

Part Five — The Basket

16 · Four Drafts

Oliver looked down. The wire basket stood by Revilo's chair, and in it, among two hundred versions of his own arrival, lay four pages that were not like the rest. They were creased and handled. They had been taken out and put back so often that the corners had gone soft. Each had a single word pencilled in the margin.

"Those are the ones I could not throw away," said Revilo. "I have lived all four. Each cost me something to write. I cannot tell you which of them is true."

Oliver took them out and read them one after another, silently, the way a man tries on coats. They were in the second person and the present tense, the voice Revilo used for all of them, in which a man is always just about to do what he is already doing.

The first draft — *in the margin: WAKE*

You sit down in the first chair and finish the sentence yourself. You say it aloud, in the plain voice, in the room, where it can be heard: *Wake up.*

"Yes," says the man at the desk. "That is the correct one."

Silvora Reefs stops. Not violently; it will simply not be the case, the way a thing is not the case when nobody is putting it. The green lamps do not go out, because they were never lit. The harbour was never wet. The fog that never quite cleared did not clear because it was a clause in a sentence somebody has now stopped writing. Darek Dwayne Wayne, who drove down to a slipway at four in the morning, has the cone made before the bell over the door has finished. And then he does not. And then there is no bell. And then there is no door.

You wake in an ordinary room. It is not nine feet by eleven. There is a window with weather behind it, doing what weather does, unbeautifully, without a front coming through the lounge at ten and without anybody's voice changing on the word *sky.* Your watch lies on the table. Twenty past six. The second hand is going, sweeping, arriving somewhere and leaving it. You look to your left from habit, and the room is only a room.

You have the language back, and it cost the town, and the town was made of you, and so was the cost. There is nobody to tell you whether it was right. The only two people who could have argued it out are now one person in an ordinary room, with a watch on the table that is going.

You will put the argument to yourself at intervals for the rest of your life. You will take both sides. You are extremely good at taking both sides; you have had eleven years of practice, and you did not know that was what you were practising.

The second draft — *in the margin: STAY*

You push the chair back toward him and say nothing. You let him finish it.

He sits down. It takes him a moment, and the moment is not hesitation; it is a man sitting in a chair he has not used for eleven years and finding the height is wrong. He puts his hands on the machine. They are your hands with everything a sixteenth of an inch the other way.

And he finishes the sentence. You do not hear what he writes. You are not going to hear what he writes, ever, on any evening, in any town, because the thing about being described is that it is the least noticeable event available to a person. Nothing happens. Nothing has ever happened. It has been happening to you all your life at a rate of several thousand words a day, and you have never once felt it land.

You come out of the seam at the head of the stair. "Sorry about your wait," says Darek, and for the first time in eleven years the timing on the line is exactly, unremarkably right.

The rotors stop over the harbour that night and nobody mentions it. The neon at Mary's says DUDE'S DEWS & DON'TS and goes on saying it. The hallway at Hang-hai is eleven feet long whether you walk it alone or not.

It is a good town. It has been made very carefully by a man with eleven years of practice and two hundred drafts and one enormous piece of knowledge about what it costs, and he is not going to waste it.

You gave the last word to the only other person alive who could have used it, and you got a town back, and everybody in it is going to be all right. The decision is not one you will ever be able to point to. Somebody is being very careful with you. He is going to go on being

very careful for a long time, and he is good at it, and you are never going to notice, and that is not a failure of yours. It is the whole of his craft, and he learned it on you.

The third draft — *in the margin: TOGETHER*

"Two chairs," you say. "You have kept two chairs in this room for eleven years in which there was never going to be a visitor, and never going to be *room* for one, and you have never once asked yourself why, because asking why is my half of the job."

He looks at the second chair, and at his own. After a while you pull yours up beside his. The cushion has not gone down anywhere. Nobody has ever sat in it.

The sentence gets finished by two people. It takes a considerable time. He argues for a semicolon and you argue for letting the line breathe, and you argue about it for the better part of an hour, and at some point the page acquires a second line, and neither of you can afterwards say who put it there.

Silvora Reefs does not stop. It *settles.* The hallway at Hang-hai finds a length and keeps it. The forty in the west corridor stay forty, and Soliloquy measures them at Michaelmas and says nothing in couplets about it. A snake on a sign holds its coil. The ink on it has been wet for eleven years, and it dries in about four minutes.

Woolbinkle was right. If holding is possible here, then somebody has been choosing not to. The somebody was two people. Neither could do it alone, and both had spent eleven years perfectly certain that the failure was a failure of will.

Neither of you gets the last word. That is the arrangement. It is the only outcome in which the man with the ice cream is still behind his counter, running a touch previous, apologising for a wait that has not happened to anybody. The remedy was never available. That is what the form got right, in a hand better than Landy's, eleven years ago: *none available. Recommend company.*

The fourth draft — *in the margin: NEVERMIND*

You say nothing. You let the elephant finish it.

Furthermore draws himself up. The air thickens. Something vast is being assembled behind his soft eyes, something that has been waiting since before there were words to wait in, and the whole room leans toward it, and the man at the desk leans too, with the face of someone who has typed *and furthermore* a hundred times and never once heard how it ends.

"Nevermind," says the elephant, in nobody's ears, and lets all the air out at once.

It is not in words. He is older than language. It arrives as weight, and warmth at the back of the neck, and the particular pressure behind the breastbone that you have been calling him since before you had words for him: *You have both been in here talking to yourselves. I have been in here the whole time. Somebody has been listening. That was never the part in doubt.*

Revilo sits down on the floor. Not in the chair; on the floor. “I have been so *lonely,*” he says, “and there has been an elephant.”

The page in the machine is not finished by either of you. It is drawn out, carefully, by four hands, and folded twice, and put in a plastic wallet in an inside pocket over the heart, where it lives; and the sentence stays in the present continuous, unresolved, fraying gently, exactly the way this town has always run.

Silvora Reefs was never being held together by an author. It was held together by somebody being listened to. It has been over-engineered for a decade, and it turns out the load-bearing element was an irrelevant elephant with an unused saddle, who never once left.

The sentence never gets finished, and nobody keeps the language. The whole apparatus, the countdown cut into brass by hand, the Coalition and its four-lobed cards, the forty vaults settled in advance, the eleven years of somebody being extremely careful about a man who did not know he was being kept, turns out to have been two halves of one person not talking to each other, in front of a witness who has been standing in the room the entire time, older than language and unimpressed by it, waiting for one of them to stop making a case long enough for somebody else to say something.

He waited since before either of you could speak. He was never once in a hurry about it. That was the point, and it took forty-four years and a purple elephant to make it, and it was made, in the end, without a single word.

17 · The Machine

Oliver laid the four pages on the desk side by side, like cards he had been dealt and had not asked for.

“They’re all good,” he said.

“They are all drafts.”

“Each one has only one of us in it.” He touched them in turn. “In the first I speak and you’re gone. In the second you write and I’m gone. In the third we’re both here, and it’s very nice, and we still *finish* it. In the fourth neither of us does anything, and an elephant has to do it

for us." He looked at the man in the lampshade-coloured coat. "You told me it couldn't be finished by both. The third draft is both. You wrote it."

"I wrote it," said Revilo. "I did not believe it."

"Why not?"

"Because they all end. A sentence that ends is a sentence that can be taken from you; I have never once reached a full stop without losing something at it." His eyes went to the page in the machine. "And not one of those four contains the line I began with. I have never been able to type it."

"Then we won't finish it," said Oliver. "We'll type it."

He took the second chair by its back and carried it round the desk and set it down beside the first. It was not a large room. The chairs touched. Revilo looked at them, and at the desk, and then, with the air of a man lowering himself into cold water, laid his hands on the keys.

"You are the only one of us who can make a thing true by saying it," said Revilo. "I am the only one who can make it stay. It had better be both."

"I don't know the verb."

"Nor do I."

"Then it doesn't matter what it is. It's whatever we do next."

"That is not grammar."

"No," said Oliver. "It's company."

Then he said it. *And he does.* He said it aloud, in the plain voice, in a small room where it could be heard, and as he said it the keys went down under Revilo's hands in time with the words, so that the thing was spoken and written in the same second, which both of them had been certain could not be done. The room did not break. The lamp did not flicker. Something that had been held for a very long time was let go, a little.

And they do, said Oliver, and Revilo typed it.

The ribbon, when Revilo ran a thumb along it, was pale and thin and very nearly through. There was one line of ink left in it, perhaps, and perhaps not that. "That is the last," he said, and his hands were shaking. "It is the one line I could not type."

He typed it. *And furthermore*, and then the dash. The ribbon went dry on the dash, and it came out faint, the last of the ink, like breath on glass.

The sentence stood open at the margin. Neither of them knew the next line. Neither of them was ever going to. And Oliver knew, with a sudden cold in his chest, what happens to a sentence left open in the present continuous. It frays.

He turned his head.

“Go on, then,” he said to the elephant.

It was what he had said in the harbour, the first morning, to a purple shape standing in eighteen inches of water, and Furthermore drew himself up. The lamp leaned toward him. Something vast was assembled behind those soft grey eyes, something that had been waiting since before there were words to wait in, and for the length of it the three of them in a room nine feet by eleven held their breath—

“Nevermind,” said the elephant, without a sound, and let all the air out at once.

It was not a word. He was older than words, and until that moment only Oliver had ever heard him; now Revilo heard too, and went very still. It arrived as weight, and warmth at the back of the neck, and the pressure behind the breastbone that a lonely child had once named after his mother’s habit of beginning sentences she was not sure how to end: *It is all right to leave it open. I am here. I will hold the other end.*

The sentence did not fray. It hung at the margin, unfinished and witnessed, and it held.

Revilo laughed. It was a short, astonished bark, the first sound in eleven years that had come out of him without being written first. Oliver found that he was laughing too, and that his face was wet, and that neither of these facts needed to be put in a sentence.

They drew the page out of the machine with four hands and folded it twice, and Revilo found a plastic wallet in the drawer, where it had been waiting eleven years, and put the page in it, and put the wallet in the inside pocket of his coat, over the heart. He looked at the basket for a long time. He did not burn it.

“I have never thrown anything away,” he said. “I think I can keep things now without hiding them.”

The seam had always been a door. It had simply wanted two people to open it. They went through it together, into a corridor that was eleven feet long, and at the head of the stair a broad man in a hat got up from the top step, and looked at the two of them for a good while.

“Sorry about your wait,” said Darek. And then, with great gravity: “Well, now. I’m gonna need another cone.”

Epilogue — The Notebook

The rotors stopped over the harbour that night, and nobody mentioned it, which in Silvora Reefs is how a miracle is acknowledged.

In the weeks that followed, the town went on being itself with a noticeably better grip. Asimov Sobeleaux's explanation of the corridor, delivered over a pair of dividers, survived the walk to the door, to his considerable astonishment. In the long grey room above the post office, Mr Quint watched the dial on the wall go blank and decided that this was what came after one; he put the WITHDRAWN stamp in the bin, and the RESOLVED stamp after it, and sat for a while with nothing to copy, and then went down the hill and had an ice cream. Woolbinkle added one more can to the shelf, labelled *Left With Me*, and did not sell it. At six every evening an owlbear addressed the empty air between the chairs at the G.'s Spot, with great courtesy, and the man at the desk in the second mirror looked up, and nodded, and went on. The numeral under Ben's table that had only ever gone one way stopped going anywhere, and Ben took his palms off the wood and, for the first time in thirty years, decided about a mask. The vault at the end of the west corridor stood open to the width of a door. There was a kitchen in it, and nobody there, and the back door open, and light coming in from a garden. Soliloquy measured it at Michaelmas and said nothing in couplets and let it stay.

The notebook in Oliver's coat had ninety pages again. They were dry and blank and his, except for the third, which held a list: eleven names, nine ruled through. The two that remained were *Oliver Onions* and *Snoino Revilo.*

Or perhaps: *Oliver Onions. Furthermore.*

Or perhaps: *The Writer. The Written.*

Or perhaps: *The Man Who Walks. The Man Who Waits.*

He raised the monocle once more, for old times' sake. Under the gold the stain beneath his thumbnail was not ink. It was the same substance the sky over the harbour bruised with, the identical violet going to crimson, and it was not on the nail but under it, in the quick, and there was a great deal more of it than that. It went up the finger and the hand to the wrist and past the wrist, and the gold declined to show where it stopped. Across the desk, Revilo held up his own hand, stained to the wrist with the same, and they compared them for a while, like two men comparing a bill, and found it came to the same amount.

The second hand of the gold watch, which had been held mid-sweep since a morning in the harbour, completed its arc and came to rest against the pin. A spring runs down and the hand comes to rest. This one had not run down. It had been let go. After a moment,

quietly, as though somebody somewhere had decided that was long enough, it began to tick.

On the brass plate on the engine's frame, beneath its name, were four words in an off-square stencil that he had once read on a wreck. They stayed English now. He read them, and understood them, and did not say them aloud. Saying a thing aloud in Silvora Reefs is how a thing gets to be the case, and there are some things you leave for the next page.

Out beyond the walls, at an enormous distance and through no window, a town continued: a queue moving, a squeegee arcing, a pan saying *shhhk.* He could hear all of it at once and none of it individually.

The lamp did not flicker. Nothing in that room did anything at all unless it was described, and neither of them was describing anything just then, and so the room simply held.

Somewhere over his heart, in a plastic wallet, a page said:

…and he does not.

And he does.

And they do.

And furthermore—

Nevermind.

Finis.